

Bizarre start to tech in 2026

If 2025 was largely a comfortable year in tech, 2026 has chosen chaos. While a large part of the tech industry prides itself on roadmaps, carefully orchestrated leaks and predictable hype cycles, the year has opened with a series of developments that feel oddly disjointed and deeply telling.

Take Apple, for instance.

Apple signing a deal with Google's Gemini to power Siri is one of those announcements that sounds mundane on the surface but carries the weight of a major shift underneath. Apple didn't just pick an AI model. It picked an ecosystem alignment. And in doing so, it delivered a very public blow to OpenAI, which suddenly finds itself on the outside looking in at one of the most valuable consumer platforms in the world.

For Apple, Gemini offers scale, multimodal depth and something else that matters deeply to Apple: leverage. Google needs Apple almost as much as Apple needs Google, if not more. That balance of power doesn't exist with OpenAI. Siri, long mocked as the weakest voice assistant in the room, may finally get a brain upgrade but the bigger story is who didn't get the call.

This was OpenAI's uncomfortable moment. If Apple's Gemini deal felt like a single punch, the broader situation at OpenAI feels more like a sustained barrage. Inside industry circles, it's no secret that OpenAI has been on something close to "code red." What started as competitive pressure has turned into a genuine leadership challenge as Gemini begins to pull ahead. Not just in benchmarks, but in perception.

This is a critical distinction. Tech dominance is as much about mindshare as it is about model performance. Gemini's growing presence across consumer products, enterprise tools and now flagship partnerships has shifted the conversation.

The irony is hard to miss. OpenAI ignited the generative AI boom, forcing every tech giant to scramble. Yet, as the dust settles, the advantage seems to be flowing back to incumbents who already own distribution,



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hardware and ecosystems. Innovation alone, it turns out, is not enough.

Then there's Sony – a brand synonymous with display excellence – quietly deciding to sell 51% stake to TCL. This isn't a headline-grabbing move, but it's one of the most telling developments of the year so far. Sony's TVs still command premium pricing, still win plaudits for image processing and still carry the brand's cinematic legacy. But, the partnership gives TCL a large control over Sony's TV and audio business.

For TCL, this is validation. For Sony, it's pragmatism. And for the industry, it's another reminder that the old hierarchies are being quietly dismantled.

The brings me to CES. If it was once tech's grand stage, this year it felt more like a well-rehearsed rerun. Outside of Samsung's tri-fold device, there was little that genuinely surprised. Incremental AI features, larger screens, thinner bezels and vaguely defined "smart" experiences dominated the show floor. CES didn't fail. It simply confirmed what many already suspected – that true innovation has moved elsewhere.

Closer home, India's tech narrative has taken a regulatory turn. Quick commerce apps being asked to curb operations marks a significant pause in a sector that has thrived on speed, scale and investor indulgence.

The clampdown signals a broader shift in India's tech ecosystem, where growth-at-all-costs is finally being questioned across the board. The next phase will demand profitability, compliance and restraint – three words that don't usually sit comfortably in startup pitch decks.

Taken individually, each of these developments might seem manageable. Together, they paint a picture of an industry in transition. Power is consolidating. Spectacle is fading. Innovation is becoming harder and riskier. If this is how the year begins, one can only imagine where it ends. But one thing is clear: tech, for all its confidence, is entering a phase of deep introspection. And that may be the most disruptive trend of all. **d**